FOR STUDENTS · YEARS 7–10

# How to Revise
# Water Safety

Most of what you were taught in this unit you will need in January, not next Friday. This is how to make it still be there.

4 techniques | 20 self-quiz questions | A real schedule | No highlighters

**Start here: the thing almost everyone gets wrong**

Reading your notes again feels like studying. It feels productive, because the words look familiar as you go. That feeling of familiarity is the problem — it is not the same thing as being able to produce the answer when nobody is showing it to you.

The method that works is the opposite one: **put the notes away and try to remember.** It feels worse. It is harder, you get things wrong, and you finish feeling less confident. That difficulty *is* the mechanism — the effort of pulling something out of your memory is what makes it stick, and re-reading skips that effort entirely.

So every technique below has the same shape: produce first, check second.

## 1. Brain dump

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**Five minutes. Blank page. No notes, no phone, no glossary.** Write down everything you can remember about this unit. Anything — numbers, rules, the order of DRS ABCD, something the teacher said, a scenario card. Messy is fine. Mind map, list, drawing, whatever comes out.

When you run out, *then* open your workbook and the glossary. Add what you missed **in a different colour**.

The different colour is the entire point. Everything in that second colour is your revision list. You have just worked out what you do not know, in five minutes, without anyone testing you.

Do this one first, before anything else. It tells you where to spend your time — which beats revising the parts you already knew, which is what most people do because those parts feel nicer.

## 2. Self-quizzing

Make your own questions. Making them is half the learning — to write a question you have to decide what actually matters, which is a harder job than answering one.

Cards work well: question on the front, answer on the back. Paper, or an app, it makes no difference. Twenty cards for this unit is plenty. Good ones from this unit:

- What do the red and yellow flags mean? → Swim between them — the patrolled area.
- DRS ABCD, in order? → Danger, Response, Send for help, Airway, Breathing, CPR, Defibrillation.
- Three steps if caught in a rip? → Stay calm and float; signal for help; swim parallel to the beach, not against the current.
- What does cold water shock do in the first minute? → Involuntary gasp, then rapid uncontrolled breathing — you lose the ability to hold your breath.

**Two rules that make the difference.** Say or write the answer *before* turning the card over — thinking “yeah I know that one” and flipping is just re-reading with extra steps. And when you get one right, do not retire the card; put it to the back and see it again later.

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## 3. Ask yourself *why*

Recalling a fact is the first step. Being able to explain *why* it is true is what lets you use it in a situation nobody warned you about — which is the only situation that ever actually happens.

So after each fact, ask yourself the follow-up:

| You remembered… | Now ask yourself… |
|---|---|
| Swim parallel to the beach, not straight in. | **Why** does swimming straight for shore fail? What is the water doing to you? |
| Never swim out to rescue someone. | **Why** is a strong swimmer still at risk? What does a panicking person do to a rescuer? |
| A quarter of Victorian drowning deaths were in home environments. | **Why** would home be dangerous? What does that say about “swim between the flags” as the whole answer? |
| Alcohol increases drowning risk. | **How**, specifically? Name the mechanism, not just the link. |

If you cannot answer the right-hand column, you have a fact without an explanation. It will not survive until summer, and it will not help you in a real decision.

This works even better out loud with someone else — take turns asking each other “why?” until one of you runs out. Whoever runs out first has found their revision topic.

## 4. Summarise from memory, then check

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Pick one topic — rips, or DRS ABCD, or inland waterways. Close everything. Write a short explanation of it as if you were teaching someone who had never heard of it.

*Then* open your notes and mark your own summary. What did you leave out? What did you get slightly wrong? What did you explain in a way that would confuse somebody?

Teaching it to an actual person is better again, because they interrupt you with the questions you did not think of. A younger sibling is ideal — they have no idea what you mean and will say so.

## When to do it

Doing all your revision in one session the night before works for the test and is gone a fortnight later. Spreading the same total time over four shorter sessions produces far better long-term recall, for the same effort. This is one of the most reliable findings in the whole of learning research, and almost nobody acts on it.

| When | How long | What to do |
|---|---|---|
| **Tonight** | 5 min | Brain dump. Mark the gaps in a second colour. That is tonight finished. |
| **This weekend** | 10 min | Make your cards — aim at the gaps you found, not the things you already knew. |
| **In two weeks** | 10 min | Run the cards. You will have forgotten some. That is expected, and re-learning them now is exactly what makes them stay. |
| **Before summer** | 15 min | Run the cards once more, then do the 20 questions below with nothing in front of you. |

That last one is the one that counts. Victorian drowning deaths peak over summer. Whatever is still in your head in December is the part of this unit that was worth doing.

## What not to bother with

- **Highlighting.** Feels like work, does almost nothing. You end up with a colourful page you still cannot recall. If you highlight, do it to decide what goes on a card — then use the card.
- **Re-reading notes.** Covered above. Familiar is not the same as known.
- **Copying notes out neatly.** This is handwriting practice.
- **Cramming.** It genuinely works for about 48 hours, and that is the trap — it works just well enough that people keep doing it. For a unit you need in January, it is wasted time.

## Twenty questions — no notes

Write your answers down before you check any of them. Writing them is not optional — reading the question, thinking "I know this", and scrolling to the answer is the one mistake this whole guide is about.

1. **How many people drowned in Victoria in 2024–25?**
2. **Which three environments accounted for most of those deaths, and roughly what share each?**
3. **How many of the 52 were aged 15–24?**
4. **What was unusual about public swimming pools in 2024–25?**
5. **Why is a rate per 100,000 people more useful than a raw count when comparing two groups?**
6. **What do the red and yellow flags mean?**
7. **Name two visual signs of a rip current.**

8. **Why is calm-looking water at a surf beach a warning sign rather than a reassurance?**

9. **What are the three things to do if you are caught in a rip?**

10. **What does DRS ABCD stand for?**

11. **Why is Danger first, rather than getting straight to the person?**

12. **What is the compression rate for CPR, and the compression-to-breath ratio?**

13. **Why is a throw rescue safer than a swim rescue, even for a strong swimmer?**

14. **Name three things you could realistically throw to someone in trouble.**

15. **What does cold water shock do in the first minute of immersion?**

16. **Give two reasons inland waterways are more dangerous than they look.**

17. **Name two specific ways alcohol increases drowning risk.**

18. **What does drowning actually look like, and why do bystanders miss it?**

19. **Is 'patrolled beach' a property of the place or of the time? Explain.**

20. **A boat carries two life jackets stowed under the seat. Is everyone aboard protected? Why or why not?**

## Answers

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Mark honestly. A nearly-right answer that you could not have said out loud to someone is a wrong answer for revision purposes.

1. **How many people drowned in Victoria in 2024–25?**

   52.

2. **Which three environments accounted for most of those deaths, and roughly what share each?**

   Coastal about 38%, inland waterways about 29%, home environments about 25%.

3. **How many of the 52 were aged 15–24?**

   Seven — about one in eight.

4. **What was unusual about public swimming pools in 2024–25?**

   There were no drowning deaths in Victorian public pools — the first time since 2019–20.

5. **Why is a rate per 100,000 people more useful than a raw count when comparing two groups?**

   Because the groups are different sizes. A bigger group will usually have more deaths even if it is no more at risk. The rate adjusts for population so the comparison means something.

6. **What do the red and yellow flags mean?**

   The area between them is patrolled by lifesavers and is where you should swim.

7. **Name two visual signs of a rip current.**

   Darker, deeper-looking water; a calmer gap with no breaking waves; foam or sand trailing out to sea; a rippled surface against surrounding choppy water. Any two.

8. **Why is calm-looking water at a surf beach a warning sign rather than a reassurance?**

   Waves break on shallow sand banks. A calm, flat channel usually means deeper water with a current flowing out through it.

9. **What are the three things to do if you are caught in a rip?**

   Stay calm and float to conserve energy; raise an arm to signal for help; swim parallel to the

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beach or towards breaking waves rather than straight for shore.

**10** **What does DRS ABCD stand for?**

Danger, Response, Send for help, Airway, Breathing, CPR, Defibrillation.

**11** **Why is Danger first, rather than getting straight to the person?**

Because a second casualty helps nobody. If the situation is unsafe for you, you cannot help them at all.

**12** **What is the compression rate for CPR, and the compression-to-breath ratio?**

About 100–120 compressions per minute, 30 compressions to 2 breaths.

**13** **Why is a throw rescue safer than a swim rescue, even for a strong swimmer?**

A drowning person grabs and pushes down on whatever reaches them. Strong swimmers drown attempting rescues. From the bank you keep yourself out of the water and can still get flotation to them.

**14** **Name three things you could realistically throw to someone in trouble.**

A boogie board, an esky lid, an empty plastic container, a rope, a branch, a life jacket, a fender — anything that floats or extends your reach. Any three.

**15** **What does cold water shock do in the first minute of immersion?**

Causes an involuntary gasp followed by rapid uncontrolled breathing, so you cannot hold your breath. That is why people drown in cold water before cold itself becomes the problem.

**16** **Give two reasons inland waterways are more dangerous than they look.**

No flags, signage or patrol; water you cannot see into, hiding snags, rocks and sudden depth changes; cold water even on a hot day; currents that are invisible from the bank; long distance from help. Any two.

**17** **Name two specific ways alcohol increases drowning risk.**

It impairs judgement so people take risks they would otherwise refuse; it slows reaction time and coordination; it reduces the ability to hold breath and increases heat loss; it makes people overestimate their own swimming ability. Any two.

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**18** **What does drowning actually look like, and why do bystanders miss it?**

Usually silent and upright, mouth at water level, no shouting and no arm waving, often under within 20–60 seconds. People expect the film version, so they do not recognise it happening a few metres away.

**19** **Is 'patrolled beach' a property of the place or of the time? Explain.**

Of the time. The same beach is patrolled during patrol hours and unpatrolled outside them. The flags being in the sand is not the same as a lifesaver watching.

**20** **A boat carries two life jackets stowed under the seat. Is everyone aboard protected? Why or why not?**

No. A jacket only works if it is worn, correctly fastened. Carrying one satisfies the law; wearing one is what keeps you afloat if you end up in the water unexpectedly.

### Scoring yourself

- **17 or more.** Solid. Run the cards once before summer and you are done.
- **12–16.** Normal, and fine. Put the ones you missed on cards and do the two-week session.
- **Under 12.** Not a disaster — it means the brain dump is where to start, not the quiz. Go back to technique 1 and work from the gaps.

The questions you got wrong are the useful part of this. Nothing is learned from the ones you got right.

## For teachers

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This covers VTLM 2.0 *Revisit and review* Practice 3 — explicitly teaching and modelling revision strategies, and addressing misconceptions about ineffective study. It is written to be handed to students directly, but the strategies land far better if modelled first.

- **Run the brain dump in class** at the end of the unit week, five minutes, in silence. Students will not believe how much they cannot retrieve until they have tried it with a blank page.
- **Model the elaborative interrogation** yourself. Take a fact, ask yourself "why?" out loud, and let them hear you get partway and have to think.
- **Do the 20 questions as the pre-summer retrieval session** — cold-called, no notes. The schedule in Section 3.6 of the Teacher Resource Guide places it in the final HPE lesson before the holidays.
- **Do not grade it.** Retrieval practice works because it is low-stakes. Grading it turns it into a test and students start revising to perform rather than to remember.

Answers to questions 1–4 carry Victorian figures that change annually. They are drawn from the Life Saving Victoria *Victorian Drowning Report 2024–25*; see `DATA_PROVENANCE.md` for the update procedure.

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Student-facing revision guide. Retrieval practice, spacing and self-testing.

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